the best yardstick. It claims that those who secure over 90 per cent in the relevant subjects in the 12th boards are unable to score a higher percentile in NEET and that NEET is unfair to government school students.

The DMK has raised the pitch on the issue, saying that exemption from NEET alone can do away with such disparity and restore the autonomy of states in education. Almost all parties in the state are supporting the DMK's stand of giving admission to medical colleges on the basis of marks in the class 12 qualifying examination. Except the BJP. "NEET has broken the capitation fee mafia and ensured equal opportunity. Abolishing it entails the risk of return [of capitation fee]," says Tamil Nadu BJP chief K. Annamalai. On the issue of disparity, he adds: "A law in Tamil Nadu has brought the state syllabus on par with the CBSE syllabus. The state also provides 7.5 per cent reservation for government school students in admission to professional courses."

Doctors and medical college managements are apprehensive that withdrawing NEET may affect the quality of students and, ultimately, of doctors. They also raise the prospect of private colleges returning to their old ways, including demands for capitation fee. "NEET is a fair way to tap meritorious talent to produce skilled doctors. When states conducted their own tests, there were question paper leaks and other fraud," says Dr K. Ravindranath, founder, Global Hospitals Group, Hyderabad. Other medical experts caution that granting exemption from NEET to one state will have a domino effect and the ongoing efforts to improve the quality of medical education will suffer.

Similar legislation against NEET adopted by the previous AIADMK government was sent back by the President in September 2017. It was not presented for reconsideration within six months. Medical education is in the Concurrent List and the bill may not get assent as it seeks to carve an exception out of a central exam system. If the President declines assent this time, the option before the DMK will be to challenge the constitutional validity of Section 14 of the National Medical Commission Act, 2019, which mandates NEET.

Medical education experts point out how NEET evolved from the earlier ordeal of aspirants in the two-tier selection process—a mix of objective and subjective tests—and how multiple state-level exams have all merged into a single national-level examination. Also, it is alleged that before the introduction of NEET, several self-financing (private) medical college managements would use their clout to access the merit list of government quota seats in Tamil Nadu before the official release and include those names in the private college seats. So, when these students opted to go to a government medical college, the private college managements would rake in huge sums as capitation fees by allegedly 'selling' those seats.

8,000

UNDERGRADUATE MEDICAL SEATS in Tamil Nadu in the 2020-21 academic session, of which **55% were in private colleges**

11

NO. OF LANGUAGES, including Tamil, in which NEET is conducted

While the introduction of a common entrance test has eliminated such ills, NEET faces challenges of evolving into an enduring nationwide testing system. When the erstwhile Medical Council of India (MCI) introduced NEET in 2013, the Supreme Court had put a stay on it following petitions received against NEET. The court had said that the MCI could not interfere in the admission process. When NEET was reintroduced in 2017 and made mandatory for admission, the Tamil Nadu government slapped an ordinance which sought exemption for medical education aspirants from appearing for the common entrance test. The Supreme Court had, then, directed the Tamil Nadu government to stick to NEET and said there could be no "compromise on intellect".

NEET was initially conducted by the CBSE. While the multilingual nature of the examination allows students from state boards, or those whose medium of instruction is not English or Hindi, to easily attempt the exam, there were goof-ups as well since the regional language question papers were a translation of the paper set in English. For instance, in the Tamil version of the question paper in 2018, 49 questions had errors. The Madras High Court ordered the CBSE to grant 196 grace marks to all students who had appeared for the exam in Tamil. This was later quashed by the Supreme Court. Since 2019, NEET is being conducted by the National Testing Agency, a government entity formed specifically for the purpose of conducting entrance and recruitment examinations.

Many doctors and medical college managements in Tamil Nadu view the opposition to NEET as grandstanding by the state's politicians at the cost of glossing over the advantages of a nationwide common entrance exam. In 2017, following suicide by a student who could not secure a medical seat, the DMK tried to capitalise on the tragedy in its campaign against the entrance examination. "While the rest of India had no such issues, the DMK was pushing hard with their propaganda. The ecosystem they developed played spoilsport by constantly creating a sense of fear," says Annamalai. "Now, after playing dirty politics for four years, the DMK is not in a position to accept the reality."

Stalin, though, may have a case in demanding that NEET be made a greater level-playing field. Exemption from NEET is just one of several issues he is raising under the banner of social justice and state autonomy. Stalin is striving to rally the non-BJP-ruled states to forge a national front. None of them has responded on the NEET exemption demand yet, but with DMK on a strident path, expect the issue to remain politically hot in the days to come. ■